strange or shocking and they often exaggerated them. One such was the incidence of sati, writes Thapar.[11] So care must be taken in interpreting their words. From the following selections of the travellers' observations, we get a sense of Vijayanagar's rulers, flourishing economy and trade, social customs and festivals and more.



Figure 6. Once the royal centre

Niccolo de Conti

Years after visiting Vijayanagar in 1420, the Italian merchant Niccolo de Conti narrated stories from his Asian voyage to a scholarly scribe. Vijayanagar's circumference, Conti claims, is sixty miles and 'in this city there are estimated to be ninety thousand men fit to bear arms'. Conti says about the king of Vijayanagar, Deva Raya I:

> Their king is more powerful than all the other kings of India [and has] twelve thousand wives, of whom four thousand follow him on foot wherever he may go, and are employed